

11 Expressive constructions in Georgian and other Caucasian languages

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The study of expressive language has long labored, both literally and figuratively, under an image problem. Ideophones depicting or evoking particular kinds of sensory or perceptual experiences of languages' speakers have often been shunted to the metagrammatical margins, in part because Standard Average European languages do not grammaticalize them in quite the same way or to the same extent that some languages of Africa, Asia and the Americas often do, but also because early scholars found it difficult to characterize precisely how sensory semantics became iconically encoded as a morphosyntactic class distinct from other parts of the lexicon. In many ways, the languages of the Caucasus at Europe's outer edge epitomize this tendency. Despite constituting some one-quarter of the linguistic diversity of the continent, the typological properties of these languages such as baroque polysynthesis, ergativity and other non-nominative alignments, extremes in the number of grammatical categories and phonological inventories coded in verbal and nominal morphosyntax have often been treated as anthropologically 'other', and not taken into consideration in discussions of Europe's linguistic heritage. Surveys such as this chapter on expressives in Abkhaz-Adyghean, Kartvelian and Nakh-Daghestanian languages can help place Europe's diversity in a new light.

11.1 Variation across Caucasian languages

Expressive language in Caucasian languages manifests itself in many different ways. Dingemanse (2012, 2015, 2017, 2018) and Dingemanse and Akita (2017) define ideophones as 'marked words that depict sensory language' in the sense that:

- they are conventionalized expressions with consistent forms and meanings and not nonce formations or interjections;

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- they typically possess structural properties (of phonology or morphosyntax) that distinguish them from other classes of words;
- they depict rather than merely describe an event or state in an affective, performative or mimetic way;
- their semantic content encodes sensory information of sight, sound, or a speaker's internal psychological state.

In all these respects, ideophones and related expressive constructions behave in some ways as hybrid classes of words, often partaking in some but not all of a language's usual repertoire of grammatical properties. In some cases, expressives do not constitute a formally distinct class but nonetheless adopt a kind of statistical profile or suite of traits that sets them apart from other classes of words in a language. Consider two different sets of Georgian lexical items:

- (1) **Georgian** expressive clusters
 - a. bdǵvr-ial-eb-s
glitter-SUFF-TH-SUBJ.3.SG
'it glitters/twinkles'
 - b. bžǵlet-a
sob-MAS.NOM
'sobbing'
 - c. brč'val-i
stabbing.pains-NOM
'stabbing pains, colic'
- (2) **Georgian** expressive reduplication and consonant gradation
 - a. t'q'ap'a-t'q'up'-i
rattle-RED-NOM
 - b. tkapa-tkup-i
clap-RED-NOM
 - c. dgapa-dgup-i / dgaba-dgub-i
tromp/stomp-RED-NOM

In the first set (1), each word expresses some salient sensory experience, whether by sight (1a), sound (1b), or internal sensation (1c). Each word also manifests another feature for which Georgian is quite famous: extremely complex syllable onsets (Butskhrikidze 2002). Georgian allows up to eight consonants in a row, for example, *gv-prckvn-i-s* [OBJ.1.PL-peel-TH-SUBJ.3.SG] 'he is peeling us'. In the second set of words in (2), we see three different kinds of expressive processes: reduplication and consonant and vowel gradation. In all the forms in both (1) and (2), expressive imagery is encoded by a specific kind of phonological process to the extent that it is a salient hallmark of expressives and can be identified as such by native speakers. At the same time, in none of these cases do expressives actually constitute a separate syntactic or morphological category distinct from nouns, verbs, and so on. This is a trait that we will find in many other languages of the Caucasus examined here.

11.1.1 Variation of exponence

Researchers have found other features common among expressive constructions (Dingemanse 2012: 655). Expressives are usually intonationally and phonationally foregrounded, in that they are characterized by higher or lower pitch ranges and/or by phonation types that are not typical or are not grammaticalized as part of a given language's phonological system, such as breathy voice, creaky voice, or whispered voice. Expressives often also manifest specific kinds of morphological contrasts not found (or not found as productively) in nonexpressive language. One very common feature of such morphological expressiveness is total or partial reduplication, as in (2), but many languages also have dedicated expressive affixes. So for example in **Megrelian** (Zan; Kartvelian), in (3), an *-in* formant is often found with expressive verbs denoting emission of sound, often in combination with partial reduplication (Kadshaia & Fähnrich 2001):

- (3) **Megrelian**
- | | | | |
|--------------|-------------|--------------|-----------------------------|
| a. zirzin- | buzz | f. c'k'irin- | clank, jingle |
| b. č'urč'in- | whine, cry | g. pič'in- | stop breathing while crying |
| c. ġumin- | whine, howl | h. jujin- | mumble |
| d. švit'in- | whistle | i. k'ižin- | cry, shout |
| e. zuzin- | whistle | | |

In **Bagvalal** (Avar-Andic; Nakh-Daghestanian), speakers may indicate that an object somehow fails to live up to expected behavior for that object by the encliticization of expressive particles =*dan* or =*q'ā* to the nominal constituents under discussion (Kibrik et al. 2001: 155):

- (4)
- | | | | | |
|--|----------------|---------------|-----------------------|--------|
| a. muk'u=b=dan | hal-i-la | hinča=b=dan | dažik | ek'w'a |
| small=N=EXPR | stalk-OBL-SUP | big=N=EXPR | gourd | be |
| 'Such a small stalk for such a big gourd!' | | | | |
| b. o-šu-r | š'an=r=q'ā | šarb-da-r | q ^w a-rā-X | ek'w'a |
| this-OBL.M-ERG | small-NPL-EXPR | letter-PL-ERG | write-MS.IPF-CONV | be |
| 'He writes in such small letters' | | | | |

In some Caucasian languages, expressiveness has even become grammaticalized with a dedicated slot on the verb. In his discussion of the verbal templatic morphology of **Budukh** (Lezgetic; Nakh-Daghestanian), Alexeev (1994) notes that an expressive slot follows spatial preverbs but comes before negation and gender agreement prefixal slots:

It is also possible to identify in Budukh a specific series of expressive prefixes *-t'*, *-č'*, *-ž*, *-c* to express either the intensity with which an action takes place or the unpleasant emotions connected with the action, e.g. *čet'er'i*, to throw around; *čot'onšu*, to kick down; *yet'er'i*, to strew the lot; *q:at'orğu*, to rip right apart; *q:et'er'i*, to winnow; *q:ot'olq'ol*, *sot'olq'ol*, to be torn apart; *q:ot'onšu*, to trample; *sart'arhar*, to run; *set'er'i*, to spill out; *sot'onšu*, to make felt; *šat'orğu*, to hem (stitch); *šut'orğu*, to close up hole with a lace; *voj'onšu*, to crumple; *voj'onku*, to knead (dough) – all with prefix *-t'*-, and

q:uĉ'onxũ, to graft; *voĉ'onxũ*, to shrug; *ʃoĉ'onxũ*, to chase; *oĉ'onxũ*, to clean – all with prefix *-ĉ'*-, and so on. (Alekseev 1994: 272)

Thus in Budukh, morphosyntactic expressiveness may be seen as a category related to, but distinct from, other systems of spatial and deictic reference.

On the other hand, in **Sanzhi Dargwa** (Dargic; Nakh-Daghestanian), which has an exceptionally rich inventory of expressive verbs (for some examples, see Table 11.1; Forker 2019: 235), ideophones bear little to any discrete reduplication or other morphological cue, but instead are primarily flagged by their presence in a light-verb construction, as in (5):

- (5) a. amma ʁaʁ r-ik'-ul ca-r ik'
 but scream F-say.IPFV-ICVB COP-F DEM.UP
 'But she is screaming.'
 b. liil xurt' aʁ-ib ca-b hel-i-la ruc-be
 all<HPL> swallow do.PFV-PRET COP-HPL that-OBL-GEN sister-PL
 '[The wolf] swallowed all her sisters.'

Indeed, in this variety of Dargwa, in many cases, the only formal cue to the ideophonic character of these constructions is that the ideophone often bears some marked laryngeal feature, such as pharyngealized vowels, uvular consonants or glottalization, since some ideophones may be complements to multiple different light verbs, and vice versa.

Table 11.1 *Ideophones within light-verb constructions in Sanzhi Dargwa*

Ideophone	Light verb	Translation
ĉ'a'm	b-arq'- (N-do.PFV-)	'chew'
ĉa'χ	b-ik'- (N-say.IPFV-)	'pour'
c'ip	či-r-aʁ- (SPR-ABL-do.PFV-) b-arq'- (N-do.PFV-)	'chop off, cut off'
la'h, lap'	(ha-)b-arq'- (up-N-do.PFV-)	'flap, wave'
pa'qa'r, p'aq'	b-uq- (HPL-go.PFV-)	'shake off'
Pas	b-ik' ^w - (N-say.IPFV-), b-arq'- (N-do.PFV-)	'scatter'
Pirχ	b-arq'- (N-do.PFV-)	'light up'
q:eh	b-ik' ^w - (N-say.IPFV-)	'cough'
q'ac'	b-ik:- (N-bite.PFV-) b-ik' ^w - (N-say.IPFV-) b-ax- (N-go-)	'gnaw, bite'
s:urk'	b-arq'- (N-do.PFV-)	'press'
s:urk'	b-ik' ^w - (N-say.IPFV-)	'rub, polish'
t'a'q'	b-ert:- (N-burst.PFV-)	'crack, split'
χu'tχ	b-ik' ^w - (N-say.IPFV-)	'snore'
χ ^w a'rt	b-uq- (HPL-go.PFV-)	'flinch, cringe, wince'

Source: Forker 2019: 236.

11.1.2 *Typology as a constraint on exponence of expressives*

To a great extent, the differences in how ideophones are expressed in the three autochthonous families are understandably constrained by the overall typological profiles of the languages in question. Abkhaz-Adyghean languages manifest extremes in terms of the phonological inventories that they possess and in the extent to which they morphologize grammatical categories on syntactic heads. Thus while **Abkhaz** (Abkhaz-Abaza; Abkhaz-Adyghean) has between fifty-eight and sixty-four consonant phonemes (depending on whether we are examining the literary or nonstandard dialects respectively), it has only two underlying phonemic vowels, /a/ and /ə/, among the fewest of any language. As a result of this, expressive constructions tend to be marked as gemination of verb stem consonants, not vowels: -ss- in *á-pssa-ra* ‘sweep’ (Abzhywa dial., cf Bzyp *a-psa-ra*; Chirikba 1996: 23), *psshá-rá* (Tapant dial.; Chirikba 1996: 25). Thus the kinds of vowel gradations employed to create ideophonic lexical items in Georgian in (2) play little to no role in Abkhaz expressive language.

The languages of this family also display extremely high degrees of verbal head-marking polysynthesis – with 11 categories inflected on the verb, they rank in the second highest category of the World Atlas of Language Structures (Haspelmath et al. 2005: Ch. 22), but nouns are marked with few case or other categories. In closely related **Kabardian** (Circassian; Abkhaz-Adyghean), expressives are usually found as particles (Colarusso 1992: 158–9):

- (6) **Kabardian** expressive particles
- | | | |
|----|-------------|--------------------------------------|
| a. | q'əʔa | ‘please!’ |
| b. | ʔaw | (astonishment) |
| c. | aʔawaha | (astonishment) |
| d. | dədəd-dədəd | (pain, sorrow) |
| e. | šaakʲ | (expressive of a blow on the cheek) |
| f. | tʰaay | (expressive of a fall in a struggle) |

Because of this overall morphosyntactic orientation, dependents in this family simply lack the categories with which expressives in other languages might be manipulated.

Nakh-Daghestanian languages in contrast often have a dozen or more vowels and their morphosyntactic profile is much more highly dependent-marking. Consequently, a Nakh language like **Chechen**, with its twenty-three simple vowel distinctions (not including diphthongs) and its eight case forms, has a phonological profile that allows ideophones to manifest themselves in vowel gradations, umlaut, and ablaut. Frequently, as noted above in the case of Sanzhi Dargwa, this consists of constructions of light verbs with complements bearing ideophonic content. For example, in (7), the light verb is *əlla* ‘say’ and its object is a reduplicated noun *varq-varq* ‘croaking’ (Muslim Khulando, p.c.):

(7) **Chechen**

Varq-varq ælla phid-aš y-ara y-exaš ʔoma čoh
 croak-croak say.CV frog-PL ii-PROG.PAST ii-cry.CV.SIM pond in
 'Frogs were croaking in the pond.'

In Chechen, this ideophone for 'croak' can be modified to express the pitch of the sound: *varq-varq*, *vorq-vorq*, *vurq-vurq*. In some Caucasian languages, this use of light verbs is effectively the only strategy possible for integrating ideophonic expressions into the language. In **Udi**, a Lezgian language of Azerbaijan and Georgia, independent verbs have become a closed class such that almost all verb constructions actually involve a light verb stem as in (8) plus an incorporated element of some kind, either a noun, adverbial or some dependent verb stem. Thus in (9), a light verb *p-* 'say' has incorporated a stem *äit*- 'word' to create a new predicate 'speak' (Harris 2008):

(8) **Udi** light verbs

b- 'do', *bak-* 'become', *d-* 'make, CAUSATIVE', *p-* 'say', *ak'-* 'see', *aq'-* 'take, get, receive', *ef-* 'hold', *p'ur-* 'die', *sak-* 'push', *(u)k'-* 'eat', *uṣḡ-* 'drink', etc.

- (9) Luiza-n Udi-n muz-in äit-ne-p-e
 Louisa-ERG Udi-GEN language-INST word-3SG-say-AOR.II
 'Louisa spoke in Udi.' (Harris 2008: 214)

In Udi, this morpholexical constraint has the consequence that there are no (new) simplex expressive verbs: all expressive verbs consist of an expressive element (ideophone, noun, etc.) incorporated into a light-verb stem: *giʕgiʕz-p-esun* [laugh-say-MAS] 'laugh, chuckle', *q'ašq'aš-p-esun* [crunch-say-MAS] 'eat, crunch on', *q'aq'a-p-esun* [IDEO-say-MAS] 'drown, strangle', *t'ut'u-p-esun* [IDEO-say-MAS] 'tremble', *ḡaḡa-p-esun* [IDEO-say-MAS] 'snarl, snap' (Schulze 2005: 165).

In most languages though, expressive elements vary in precisely how integrated they are in clauses. Thus in **Archi** (Lezgian; Nakh-Daghestanian), incorporated expressives in some cases behave like simple stem formatives and thus are invisible for purposes of case assignment of other arguments in the clause (Testelec 1987):

(10) **Archi**

- a. t'ant' ziz-war
 bee.ABS buzz-say.PRS
 'The bee buzzes.'
- b. za-ri diq' u-bu χ
 I-ERG soup.ABS drink-say.PST
 'I eat the soup'
- c. jaIt'i-li zat:i-k ʕit-bo
 snake-ERG I-LOC hiss-say.PST
 'The snake hissed at me.'

Like most languages of the family, Archi is an ergative language, and so the subject *t'ant'* 'bee' of the intransitive predicate in (10a) takes

absolutive case (here, null marking); in a corresponding transitive like (10b), the incorporated form χu - ‘drink’ does not prevent the verb from assigning absolutive case to the other argument *diq* ‘soup’. In (10c) however, the expressive element λil - ‘hiss’ appears to absorb the assignment of absolutive case normally assigned to direct objects of transitive verbs, making it unavailable for the notional patient, which receives locative case. In a different ergative Lezgian language of Daghestan and Azerbaijan, **Lezgian**, expressives have completely generalized the absorption of absolutive case so that originally onomatopoeic expressives like those in (10) uniformly take ergative subjects with a single light verb *awun* ‘do’ (Haspelmath 1993: 181), as in (11)–(12):

- (11) $C_1V(r)C_2 + awun$
 a. murr-murr awun ‘purr’
 b. $\check{c}'arx-\check{c}'arx$ awun ‘crunch’
 c. žirt'-žirt' awun ‘squelch’
 d. ziw-ziw awun ‘clink’
- (12) $C_1V_1C_2rV_1C_2 + awun$
 a. t'aq'raq' awun ‘crunch’
 b. bağrağ awun ‘rumble’
 c. lešreš awun ‘splash’
 d. $\check{c}'wäqräq'$ awun ‘snap, crack’

Like the Georgian examples in (2), Lezgian expressives show varying kinds of vowel or consonant gradation, reminiscent of Semitic templatic morphology (see also §11.1.4 and §11.2).

In some languages, a distinction between different levels of integration of incorporated expressives has become grammaticalized as a marker of animacy. In **Bezht'a** (Tsezic; Nakh-Daghestanian) and **Lak** (Lakic; Nakh-Daghestanian), incorporating constructions mark subject arguments with ergative case if they are animate (13a, 14a), but absolutive case if they are inanimate (13b, 14b; Testelec, 2021):

- (13) **Bezht'a**
 a. is-t'i hic- λo -jo (Animate subject)
 brother-OBL.ERG sneeze-say-PST
 ‘Brother sneezed.’
 b. okko c'im- λo -jo (Inanimate subject)
 coin.ABS jingle-say-PST
 ‘The coin jingled.’
- (14) **Lak**
 a. $\check{c}:it$ -ul maIw-ukunni (Animate subject)
 cat-ERG meow-say.PST
 ‘The cat meowed.’
 b. granata p'aIq'-ukunni (Inanimate subject)
 grenade.ABS explode-say.PST
 ‘The grenade exploded.’

Thus in these languages the encoding of expressive forms represents a kind of covert category of animacy. In yet other languages, expressive-like forms are fully integrated into the language's formal gender-marking system. Like most northeastern Caucasian languages, nouns in **Hinuq** (Tsezic; Nakh-Daghestanian) fall into a number of different gender classes depending on how they agree with certain verbs, adjectives, adverbs and some other word-classes. In Hinuq, expressive verbs depicting the emission of sound may be nominalized by the addition of a suffix *-ni*, as in (15), and when doing so they are consistently classed with Hinuq's fifth gender otherwise associated with tools, abstract nouns, and meteorological phenomena (Forker 2013: 120):

- (15) **Hinuq**
- | | | |
|----------------------------|------------------------|--------------------|
| a. h̡ap̡a:- 'bark' | h̡ap̡-ni 'barking' | (Forker 2013: 109) |
| b. bab̡a:- 'bleat' | baba-ni 'bleating' | |
| c. dod̡o:- 'shake' | dodo-ni 'shaking' | |
| d. bub̡a:- 'bellow' (bull) | bubu-ni 'bellowing' | |
| e. p̡ap̡a:- 'chatter' | p̡ap̡a-ni 'chattering' | |

Thus in Hinuq one can largely predict which formal gender class an expressive nominalization will be.

11.1.3 Category innovation exclusive to expressives

Such cases reflect the recruitment of a pre-existing grammatical category for expressive purposes, but in many languages, expressive language manifests entirely new grammatical or phonological categories that are either not otherwise present in the language, or are very marginal. Thus many languages in the Caucasus lack a distinct voiceless labiovelar fricative /f/, but according to Sumbatova and Mutalov (2003: 3), in **Icari Dargwa** (Dargic; Nakh-Daghestanian) this phone exists marginally only within the class of ideophones like *uf-* in *uf.bik^waraj* 'blow (about someone), utter a fie'. In the core lexicon of **Khwarshi** (Tsezic; Nakh-Daghestanian) vowel-length (Khalilova 2009: 20) and of **Budukh** both vowel-length and nasalization (Azmaiparashvili et al. 2016: 148) are unknown, and yet both processes occur occasionally in those languages in expressive constructions. In **Udi**, neither consonants nor vowels exhibit length contrasts, but in some forms glottalized velar or uvular stops can become lengthened: *ek:* 'a' 'all what', *eq:* 'ara' 'how much', *t'eq:* 'ara' 'so much', features that Schulze (2005: 71) attributes to potential expressive usage. Likewise, in Udi reduplication plays virtually no role in the core grammar of the language, but does appear as a productive process in expressive forms (according to Schulze 2005: 137–8):

- (16)
- | | |
|---------------|-------------|
| a. č̣'uč̣'up' | 'curl' |
| b. k'ak'ala | 'excrement' |
| c. gugum | 'horsefly' |
| d. k'ok'oc | 'hen' |

11.1.4 Expressives as a source of lexical innovation: flora and fauna

Another almost ubiquitous way in which Caucasian languages use expressive language is as a source for names of salient animal and plant species, or words closely associated with them. This form of expressive language is indeed so widespread within the Caucasus that it may be rightly distinguished as a separate kind of lexical process. Though there is variation both within and between languages and language families, a common trend is for species names to have a reduplicative template of $\langle C_1V_1(r/l/n)(C_1)(C_2)V_1C_2 \rangle$. In many cases, the species names can be reconstructed to their respective proto-language, for example, **Georgian** *k'ak'abi* 'partridge' and **Megrelian** *k'ok'obe* 'partridge', since they underwent separately identifiable sound-changes (in this case, the raising/backing of Proto-Kartvelian **a* to /o/ in Megrelian). In other cases, it seems likely that a single lexical item was loaned between languages (including closely related ones), or was innovated separately according to a similar expressive template. This is true of the words for 'nightingale' across the Caucasus, which have often borrowed the root *bulbul-* from Persian.

11.1.5 Expressives as a locus of diachronic change

Finally, expressives may also be a source for or a locus of diachronic change. For one, ideophones may become grammaticalized into other constructions and subsequently lose any semantically decompositional meaning that is accessible to speakers. Thus in the **Sanzhi Dargwa** example above, it is difficult to isolate the difference in meaning between *s:urk' b-arq'* [IDEO-do.PFV-] 'press' and *s:urk' b-ik'*^w [IDEO-say.IPFV-] 'rub, polish', despite the fact that each element of these constructions is formally quite distinct. Over time, such ideophones may be fully grammaticalized as part of some other element.

The reverse is also true: in some cases, non-ideophonic content may begin to behave like ideophones, at least in a formal sense. In recent work, Gilles Authier has documented so-called pseudo-ideophones in Archi, in which a lexical contrast arises by reanalysis of some part of a simplex verb as complex (Authier 2022). He gives examples like *ʒum-mus* 'pull' and *t:um-mus* 'flee' in which the stem's initial consonant has innovated what appears to be an expressive contrast:

- (17) lo-bur x:ams:-i-ʒ'iʃ b-ułne
 child-PL.NOM bear-OBL-SUBEL HPL-flee.PF
 'The children fled from the bear'

Because the form with initial *t-* appears cognate to a lexeme *-ǵn* in the related **Kryts** language (Lezgian; Nakh-Daghestanian) without expressive

Table 11.2 *Floral and faunal terms derived from expressives in Caucasian languages*

Family	Language	Species name
Abkhaz-Adyghean	Abkhaz	a-h ^w əh ^w 'pigeon', patpatə- 'to flutter, quiver (of a bird)', a-c ^w əpc ^w əp 'sp. of bird', a-č ^w ənəč ^w əhə 'bird's stomach', ġyarġyar- 'to frighten birds in fields or kitchen gardens', a-k ^w ark ^w alaməšw ^w 'sp. of small lizard', a-c ^w ərc ^w əré 'sound made by dragon-fly or snake'
	Abaza	h ^w əh ^w 'pigeon'
Kartvelian	Georgian	k'irk'it'a 'kestrel', guguli 'cuckoo', bulbuli 'nightingale', but ^w but ^w a 'warbler', k'ok ^w orina 'sandpiper', c ^w ivc ^w iva 'chickadee', k'ak ^w abi 'partridge', k ^w ač ^w k ^w ač ^w i 'magpie', tutiq ^w uši 'parrot', q ^w arq ^w at ^w i 'stork, spoonbill', xoxobi 'pheasant', baq ^w aq ^w i 'frog'
	Megrelian	ğerğet ^w i 'goose', ġorğonji 'goose', k'ok ^w obe 'partridge', dadulia 'little chick', t ^w urt ^w urue 'turtle dove', č ^w k ^w ič ^w k ^w it ^w ia 'ant', ġġiġit ^w ia 'ant'
	Svan	parpānd 'blackbird', č ^w inč ^w wer 'bird's nest', metetx 'bat'
Nakh-Daghestanian	Aghul	q:laraq:lal 'magpie', c ^w urc ^w ul 'marten', mizmiz 'mosquito'
	Akhvakh	koq:o 'frog', žožo 'fly'
	Avar	žužuk 'quail', λ:īλ:ī 'kind of song bird', k ^w ałk ^w ał 'woodpecker'
	Archi	zimzi 'mosquito'
	Bezht'a	qōqōtō 'woodpecker', šašu 'swallow'
	Budukh	kakıl 'partridge', čič 'lizard'
	Chechen	šoršal 'thrush, blackbird', qoqa 'pigeon'
	Dargwa	š:ałaki 'quail', wadwadi 'hoopoe' (Akusha), čič:ala 'snake', imi?ala 'stinging insect, ant' (Akusha), zimizal 'stinging insect, ant' (Chiragh), q:ulq:a 'crow'
	Karata	č ^w anč ^w ara 'butterfly, quail'
	Khinalug	k'ak'id 'partridge', čänč 'pigeon'
	Hunzib	q'alq'ala 'magpie'
	Lak	q:aqnu 'partridge', ɤanɤarat ^w i 'beetle'
	Lezgian	kutkut ^w 'hoopoe', čurčul 'snake, worm' çuçul
	Rutul	siriçal 'marten'
	Tabasaran	q:aq:uba 'partridge', mizmiz 'mosquito', q:laraq:lar 'magpie'
	Tsakhur	kıçaçaj 'sparrow', t'aqt'aq ^w aj 'woodpecker' bizbiza 'mosquito'

function (cf. *ji-ḡn-iṣ* ‘pull’), the Archi form with initial *λ*-may represent an incipient expressive morphological contrast.

In languages with long written histories, we can also trace the evolution of the formal exponence of such expressive constructions by looking at how they change in frequency and function in historical texts. The Caucasian language with by far the longest written history in the region, Georgian, possesses a rich wealth of historical texts dating from the fifth century CE onward. These can allow us to see how reduplicative patterns for expressive verbs like *ḡaḡadeba* ‘call out to, wail to’ (first att. fifth century) or *k’amk’ameba* ‘sparkling’ (first att. eleventh century) expand and change over many centuries:

- (18) *The Martyrdom of Queen Shushanik* (c. 476–482 CE)
 sen-i ... mo-i-c’i-a mis zeda,romel-sa=c=igi
 illness-NOM PVB-PRV-contract-3SG3SG.GEN on which-DAT=REL=DET
 c’inaysc’ar u-ḡaḡa-d-eb-d-i
 before.hand PRV-wail.out-put-TH-IMPF-1/2
 ‘She contracted an illness about which you were crying out before ...’
- (19) *The Sixth Meeting of the Ecclesiastical Council of Carthage* (c. 1010–1030 CE)
 xolo ḡmert-t-mtavrob-it-ta k’amk’am-eb-a-ta=gan
 but God-GEN-government-INST-GEN.PL twinkle-TH-MAS-GEN.PL=from
 es-oden-i natel-i a-ku-s ḡirs-ta
 this-QUANT-NOM light-NOM PRV-have.INAN-3SG worthy-DAT.PL
 ‘But from the twinklings of the Divine Government those who are worthy have so much light ...’

Such a long textual heritage allows scholars to know that apparent expressive constructions with particular features like reduplication exclusive to expressives are not new innovations in recent centuries, but long-enduring, stable features of the language.

11.2 Expressive language in Georgian

The most extensive previous treatment of expressive language in Georgian is that of Holisky (1988), who examines a number of familiar features from the previous literature. For Holisky, expressives are a syntactically distinct form-class that denote ‘varied kinds of sensation, the impingement of the material world ... upon the senses’ (citing Emeneau 1969) that also ‘convey with vivid clarity and eloquence the perceptual qualities of objects and events’ (citing Johnson 1976). In addition to the criteria noted by Dingemanse (2012), Holisky found a variety of other traits either universally or statistically likely to appear, including:

- (20)
- they do not always observe the same phonotactic patterns established for the rest of the lexicon;
 - some phonological rules may not hold for this class; or vice versa, special rules may apply only to this class;
 - they are restricted to a few syntactic positions, often in isolation;

- d. they tend not to be negatable or quantifiable;
- e. they describe situations in a holistic way, closer to being semantic propositions than predicates or arguments;
- f. they often exhibit stylistic restrictions, e.g. to children's speech, or oral and not written language

Holisky's investigation (undertaken with Nana Kakhadze) focused exclusively on one subclass of expressives: manner of speaking verbs. After examining more than one hundred such verbs divided into loud sounds, high-pitched sounds, indistinct sounds, and so on, she found that many of them lack lexical discreteness, in the sense that they form quasi-paradigmatic structures amongst themselves. On the one hand, there are verbs like those in (21) through (23), in which a fixed consonantal templatic matrix alternates with different vowel qualities, and high vowels reflect higher, louder pitch and lower vowels reflect lower pitch (Holisky 1988: 57):

Verbs of shrill, squeaky complaint

- (21) č'uč'q'un-eb-s squeal-TH- č'ic'q'in-eb-s squeak-TH- č'ač'q'an-eb-s squawk-TH-
 3SG 'S/he is squealing' 3SG 'S/he is squeaking' 3SG 'S/he is squawking'

Verbs of low, loud complaining

- (22) jujgun-eb-s 'speaks peevishly, jijgin-eb-s jajgan-eb-s 'grumbles
 nasally' 'mutters' loudly'

Verbs of soft, child-like talking

- (23) t'ut'un-eb-s 'mumbles t'it'in-eb-s 'burbles, [cf. t'a'tana 'scolder,
 softly' drivels' remonstrator']

On the other hand, there are also expressive verbs in which the vowel stays fixed, while we see various kinds of consonant gradation, often reflecting an onomatopoetic hierarchy of [voiced > aspirated > glottalized]:

Verbs of children's crying

- (25) jgav-i-s 'weeps loudly, čxav-i-s 'screeches, č'q'av-i-s '(owl, jackal) yowls,
 howls' yowls' howls'

Verbs of sobbing

- (26) zlukun-eb-s 'bawls, sobs loudly' slukun-eb-s 'sobs loudly'

Verbs of soft, child-like talking

- (27) bluq'un-eb-s 'stutters, stammers' bluk'un-eb-s 'stutters, stammers'

Holisky also found that glottalization is associated with high pitch, with seventeen of the eighteen words associated with high-pitch having glottalized sounds, while voiced consonants are associated with lower pitch and negative attitudinal perspectives of the speakers (1988: 60):

Glottalized		Voiced	
<i>c'rip'in-eb-s</i>	squeaks, peeps	<i>burt'q'un-eb-s</i>	mumbles, growls
<i>c'iv-i-s</i>	screeches, shrieks	<i>burdğun-eb-s</i>	mutters, grumbles
<i>č'uč'q'un-eb-s</i>	squeals	<i>dudğun-eb-s</i>	talks through one's nose
<i>č'q'iv-i-s</i>	screeches, shrieks	<i>bluq'un-eb-s</i>	stutters, stammers
<i>k'iv-i-s</i>	shrieks	<i>bubun-eb-s</i>	bellows, lows

However, perhaps the most significant generalization in Holisky's work is that these manner of speaking verbs also overwhelmingly bear the same morphosyntactic profile: they belong to a class of 'medial' verbs, or atelic, agentive intransitive predicates that pattern differently from transitive predicates and stative intransitive predicates in terms of case, agreement and tense/aspect/mood morphology (see also Holisky 1983).

To understand this, it is important to understand the complicated system of Georgian case and agreement. Georgian is a Split-S language in terms of its morphosyntactic alignment (Harris 1981, Harris 1985, Wier 2005, Wier 2011, Wier 2014, Baker 2017): it has two classes of intransitive predicates, one of which patterns like the subject of transitive verbs, and another which patterns separately (though not quite like the objects of transitives). But in addition to this, Georgian features crosscutting tense-aspect-mood (TAM) splits, and different conjugations pattern differently in different TAM-combinations. In other words, one cannot say that a particular case desinence directly reflects a specific grammatical function, because there is a many-to-many-to-many relationship of case, agreement and grammatical function. So for example in (28) we see case-shifts from one tense to the next:

- (28)
- a. *bavšv-i* male *i-č'uč'q'un-eb-s*
 child-NOM soon PRV-squeal-TH-3SG
 'The child will squeal soon.'
 - b. *bavšv-ma* *i-č'uč'q'un-a*
 child-NARR PRV-squeal-AOR.3SG
 'The child squealed.'
 - c. *bavšv-s* *u-č'uč'q'un-i-a*
 child-DAT PRV-squeal-PF-3SG
 'The child has apparently squealed.'

In (28a), the subject in the present/future series form is *bavšv-i* 'child' with nominative case *-i*, while in the aorist series form in (28b) it is *bavšv-ma* with narrative (ergative) *-ma*, and in the perfect-evidential series it is *bavšv-s* with dative *-s*.

To get a holistic concrete sense of this, Tables 11.3 and 11.4 display the general system of case assignment and tense-aspect formation for Georgian

Table 11.3 *Georgian case assignment across TAM series and conjugational class*

Transitive		'Medial' Intransitive	Stative Intransitive	Dative- Affective
PRESENT- FUTURE	SUBJ: NOM IOBJ: DAT	SUBJ: NOM	SUBJ: NOM	SUBJ: DAT
	DOBJ: DAT			DOBJ: NOM
AORIST	SUBJ: NARR IOBJ: DAT	SUBJ: NARR	SUBJ: NOM	SUBJ: DAT
	DOBJ: NOM			DOBJ: NOM
PERFECT- EVIDENTIAL	SUBJ: DAT IOBJ: PP	SUBJ: DAT	SUBJ: NOM	SUBJ: DAT
	DOBJ: NOM			DOBJ: NOM

Sources: Harris 1981, Holisky 1983, Wier 2011

Table 11.4 *Formal criteria distinguishing different conjugation classes*

	Transitive	'Medial'	Stative Intransitive	Dative- Affective
<i>FORMATION OF THE FUTURE SUBSERIES</i>	Preverb	i- ... -eb	Preverb	e- ... -eb
<i>3SG SUFFIX IN PRESENT</i>	-s	-s	-a	-s
<i>3SG SUFFIX IN FUTURE</i>	-s	-s	-a	-a

Sources: Harris 1981, Holisky 1983, Wier 2011

verbs across different series and conjugation classes. In Table 11.3, the PRESENT-FUTURE series of verb paradigms, the first conjugation of transitives assign *nominative* case (NOM) to their grammatical subject/agent (SUBJ), *dative* case (DAT) to their indirect object/goal (IOBJ), and also *dative* to their direct object/theme (DOBJ), if they are ditransitive. However, when we shift to the AORIST series, verbs in this series of paradigms now assign *narrative* (AKA 'ergative') to their subject, *dative* to their indirect object, and *nominative* to their direct object. When we shift yet again to PERFECT-EVIDENTIAL series of verb forms, the case array changes yet again: the notional subject is marked by *dative* case, the notional direct object by *nominative* case, and the notional indirect object not by a case at all but by a postpositional phrase headed by =*tvīs* 'for'. Table 11.4 likewise identifies the formal criteria by which these classes are distinguished.

Very many formal explanations have been proffered for the technical origin and synchronic functioning of this complex system (e.g. see Harris 1981 arguing for a change in grammatical function; cf. Wier 2011 for an account involving two distinct levels of argument structure; see also Nash 2017 for an account based on theta-licensing). For the purpose of expressives however the

significance of all of this is that the two classes of intransitive verbs differ in each of these different tense-aspect-mood series, a class of ‘medial’/agentive intransitives which patterns like the subject of transitives, and a class of stative intransitives that patterns separately. The expressive verbs that Holisky examined pattern like the first of these two intransitive classes: as ‘medial’, atelic, agentive intransitive verbs.

This generalization by Holisky is significant, because it shows that expressive manner-of-speaking verbs belong to a distinct formal class not just in their morphology, but also in their patterns of nominal case assignment and verbal tense-aspect formation and agreement.

11.3 Extensions and implications

This leaves open the question: do all Georgian expressives manifest these features, or just the manner-of-speaking verbs? To investigate this, I collected more than 150 expressives outside this domain of manner-of-speaking verbs to examine the extent to which they matched Holisky’s internally consistent generalizations (see Table 11.5). The database focuses on expressives of the emission of light, emission of sound, and salient movement, and includes not only verbs, but a number of nominals or adverbials which also depict sensory data and share some of the same features as verbs. For example in (29), among verbs of emission of sound, we find nominal triplets with many of the expressive traits discussed above:

- (29) a. xrial-griali ‘banging, clatter’
 b. xrial-ǵriali ‘very loud and constant noise’
 c. xrial-xriali ‘prolonged rattle, roar, thundering’

Table 11.5 *Statistical distribution of features of morphosyntactic exponence across different expressive classes*

	Emission of light	Emission of sound	Salient movement	Control sample
TOTAL	52	51	50	175
• verbs	40	19	41	53
Reduplication	18 (35%)	23 (45%)	30 (60%)	2 (1%)
• full	16 (31%)	7 (14%)	10 (20%)	0 (0%)
• partial	2 (4%)	16 (31%)	20 (40%)	2 (1%)
Root cluster >3	10 (19%)	5 (10%)	5 (10%)	13 (7%)
Medial verb	11 (28% of verbs)	8 (42% of verbs)	19 (46% of verbs)	1 (2% of verbs)
Voiced fricative	19 (37%)	4 (8%)	9 (18%)	41 (23%)

Table 11.6 *Case assignment of different classes of expressives across tense-aspect series*

	Emission of light	Emission of sound	Salient movement
PRES	cecxl-i bdǧvrial-eb-s fire-NOMglow-TH- 3SG 'The fire is glowing'	panjara raxrax-eb-s window.NOM rattle-TH- 3SG 'The window is rattling'	bavšv-i braxun-eb-s child-NOMstomp-TH- 3SG 'The child is stomping'
AOR	cecxl-ma i-bdǧvrial-a fire-NARRPRV-glow- AOR.3SG 'The fire glowed'	panjara-mi-raxrax-a window.NARRPRV- rattle-AOR.3SG 'The window rattled'	bavšv-ma i-braxun-a child-NARRPRV-stomp- AOR.3SG 'The child stomped'
PERF-EVID	cecxl-s u-bdǧvrial-i-a fire-DATPRV-glow- PF-3SG 'The fire has apparently glowed'	panjara-s u-raxrax-i-a window-DATPRV-rattle- PF-3SG 'The window has apparently rattled'	bavšv-s u-braxun-i-a child-DATPRV-stomp- PF-3SG 'The child has apparently stomped'

As a control, the database also included 175 basic lexical items of all different lexical classes against which the features of the expressive sets could be compared. These basic lexical items were created from the list of basic semantic primitives used by the Loan Word Typology database (Haspelmath & Tadmor 2009), which was expressly designed to make the creation of semantically commensurable basic word lists possible.

When we compare these additional classes of expressives to that earlier work, we find that they do largely cohere with Holisky's findings, but with interesting twists. We see similar kinds of morphological exponence in the form of reduplication, expressive ablaut and consonant gradation, as well as expressive affixal formatives such as *-in*, *-un* or *-ial*. We also see that, like manner of speaking verbs, many verbs that denote emission of light or inanimate sources of sound also fall into Holisky's medial class of verbs in terms of their case-assignment and tense/aspect/mood desinences.

However, it is also clear that there arise other salient features that are either absent, or rarer, in the class of manner-of-speaking verbs. For example, while the data published by Holisky examined included forms with complex onsets with two segments like /č'q'/, /dǧ/, /jǧ/, /čx/, /t'q'/, and so on, in lexical items depicting emission of light, we often find extremely complex onsets of three, four, and even five segments in length, at more than double the frequency (19 percent) of the control sample (7 percent), and elevated rates in the other two classes:

Table 11.7 *Expressive verbs of emission of light or sound or of salient movement*

Expressive with complex onset	English gloss
bdǵvrial-eb-s	glitters, glares
k'rtol-av-s	glitter, quiver, shiver
mbdvinvar-eb-s	flicker, glimmer
mbzin-av-i	brilliant
mbžut'-av-i	flickering, glimmering
ckrial-eb-s	moves gracefully, quickly, shimmers
bžǵvrial-eb-s	sparkles, glitters
brč'q'vial-eb-s	sparkles, glitters, is radiant
brč'q'vin-av-s	glitters, shines
bdǵvin-av-s	walk about roaring (of lions)
mžǵer-i	voiced (e.g. consonant)
mbdǵvin-av-i	roaring
džgrial-eb-s	crashes, bangs
džgnar-av-s	gnaws on s.th.
žǵl-i-s	cracks s.th. (e.g. glass)
brtq'el-brtq'el-i	high-flown, bombastic speech
k'rt'n-i-s	(bird) preens for lice
prckvn-i-s	peels s.th.
čkro	noise, sound of s.o.'s voice
t'q'lap'i	fruit-leather (made by crushing fruit)
t'q'laša-t'q'luši	continuous cracking, thwacking sound

This stands in contrast to the verbs of emission of sound or salient movement, fewer of which manifest extremes of consonant clusters in onset position. While such long consonant clusters can be found occasionally in nonexpressive parts of the lexicon (e.g. *bžǵali* 'light grey', *prckili* 'reddish stone', *dngra* 'fit, strapping, imposing', *p'rc'k'ali* 'splinter', etc.), they are considerably more frequent among expressives. It seems likely that this reflects an exaptation from Georgian's typologically unusual syllable structure toward making expressives more salient in discourses. But it is also difficult to describe in purely morphological terms, since if there is any generalization to be had here, it is on a highly abstract prosodic level – not unlike the prosodic quasi-templates seen in Holisky's earlier study described in §11.2.

Another at least ostensible feature found extensively in verbs of emission of light, in addition to the manner of speaking verbs which Holisky investigated, is the presence of one or more voiced fricatives, often /ǵ/, /ž/, /v/ or /z/:

Table 11.8 *Salience of voiced fricatives in expressives depicting emission of light*

Expressive with voiced fricative	English gloss
živživ-eb-s	twinkles, glimmers; tweets
žik'žik'-eb-s	twinkles, glimmers
žol-av-s	flickers, glimmers
žužg-av-s	flickers, glimmers
bzin-av-s	sparkles, glitters
gudgud-eb-s	sparkles, dazzles with brightness
gadgad-eb-s	sparkles, glows
vasvas-eb-s	flashes, sparkles, shimmers
gvelp-av-s	burns down to embers
varvar-a	incandescent glow
na-gverd-al-i	glowing embers/coals
gviv-i-s	glows, flashes red, simmers
guzguz-eb-s	(fire) crackles
gizgiz-eb-s	blazes up, roars
elvar-eb-s	dazzles, shines brightly

Do these voiced fricatives have the same causal role in expressive formation that reduplication, medial verbs or root clusters do? Here we can see the usefulness of the control sample, where voiced fricatives occur at approximately the same rate (21 percent of all expressives in Table 11.5) as the control sample (23 percent). Thus we can exclude this feature as an artefact of the sample creation, a merely apparent, and not actual, causal factor in expressive formation.

Lastly, there is one category of expressive that did not cohere with Holisky (1988)'s results, but in an indirect way they throw her generalizations into sharper relief. These are the set of expressive verbs with ingressive aspect, which in Georgian are treated morphosyntactically as a kind of synthetic passive verb with an ingressive *-d* suffix:

Table 11.9 *Ingressive expressive predicates*

Ingressive expressive	English gloss
ga-bdǵvin-d-eb-a	will (begin to) sparkle, dazzle
ga-ǵadǵad-d-eb-a	(fire) will (begin to) sparkle/glow
ča-nak' vercxl-d-eb-a	(wood) will turn into glowing embers
ga-picx-d-eb-a	will get hot, heated
t'q'd-eb-a	break, shatter
še-mo-braxun-d-eb-a	will come stomping in
čačxap'un-d-eb-a	will rush down noisily
č'ianur-d-eb-a	drags itself out endlessly; is badly delayed
a-baban-d-eb-a	will stagger, shiver from fever
a-ǵant'al-d-eb-a	will stagger (from one's bed)
dzundzul-d-eb-a	come out at a trot
c'a-ǵerǵet'-d-eb-a	waddle about like a goose
a-q'vir-d-eb-a	will begin to cry out, clamor
a-raxrax-d-eb-a	will begin to rumble
a-prut'un-d-eb-a	will snort

Although in some cases these verbs are lexically underived (e.g. *t'q'd-eb-a* 'it will break, shatter') many of these verbs are effectively ingressive forms of noningressive alternants seen above and in the rest of the database. Such forms often have reduplication, large consonant clusters, and depictive semantics like noningressive expressives. They differ however in one very important point: they are never medial verbs. Instead, they have the morphological and syntactic properties of the second class of intransitive verb in Georgian: the stative intransitives (see Table 11.3). Like statives, they form their future desinences with a lexically specific preverb, inflect their present tense forms with stative *-a* (unlike the transitive and medial *-s*; see Table 11.4), and they assign exclusively nominative case to their single argument, as in the examples in Table 11.10. Thus the exceptions to Holisky's generalization about expressives themselves constitute a formal class.

Thus unlike the forms in Table 11.6 which change from one series to the next, the expressives in Table 11.10 take *-i* nominative case subjects across tense/aspect series and consistently take preverbs characteristic of ingressesives and stative intransitive verbs.

The implication of this second class of expressive predicate is that the morphosyntactic features of expressives – the way they assign case to their arguments, the way aspectual desinences are assigned in a given paradigm – cannot be a direct expression of any one of their thematic roles, or of grammatical function, or of argument structure, or of their lexical semantics. Instead, the two different classes of expressives illustrate how the many-to-many relationship of case, agreement and tense-aspect marking is an

Table 11.10 *Case assignment of different classes of ingressive expressives across tense-aspect series*

	Emission of light	Emission of sound	Salient movement
PRES/ FUT	cecxl-i ga-bdǵvrin-d-eb-a fire-NOM PVB-sparkle-INGR-TH-3SG 'The fire will start to sparkle'	panjara a-raxrax-d-eb-a window.NOM PVB-rumble-INGR-TH-3SG 'The window will start to rumble'	bavšv-i še-mo-braxun-d-eb-a child-NOM PVB-VENTstomp-TH-3SG 'The child will come stomping in'
AOR	cecxl-i ga-bdǵvrin-d-a fire-NOM PRV-sparkle-AOR.3SG 'The fire started to sparkle'	panjara a-raxrax-d-a window-NOM PVB-rumble-INGR-AOR.3SG 'The window rumbled'	bavšv-i še-mo-braxun-d-a child-NOM PVB-VENT-stomp-INGR-AOR.3SG 'The child came in stomping'
PERF-EVID	cecxl-i ga-bdǵvrin-eb-ul-a fire-NOM PRV-sparkle-TH-PF-3SG 'The fire has apparently started to sparkled'	panjara a-raxrax-eb-ul-a window. NOM PVB-rumble-TH-PF-3SG 'The window has apparently started to rumble'	bavšv-i še-mo-braxun-eb-ul-a child-NOM PVB-VENT-stomp-TH-PF-3SG 'The child has apparently come in stomping'

underlying one, in which different parts of the grammatical architecture can trigger assignment to one or more of these paradigmatic subsystems. Thus expressives may be assigned to the medial class of atelic, agentive intransitive verbs, but if they take on ingressive semantics, this triggers wholesale reassignment to the class of ingressive predicates, with a consequent total shift of case-assignment, agreement and tense-aspect formation.

11.4 Concluding remarks

This chapter has surveyed the different ways in which expressive predicates behave across the understudied languages of the Caucasus. We have seen how expressive constructions exhibit marked variation in exponence, ranging from verbal stem suffixation, to nominal cliticization, to dedicated templatic slots on the verb, to complicated systems ideophones being incorporated in different ways into light-verbs. We have also seen how the extreme typological diversity of the Caucasus has acted as a constraint on how expressive language may manifest itself in different languages. Because the three autochthonous families differ so radically from each other in their phonological, morphological and syntactic profiles, it is difficult to find traits common to expressive constructions across the region which are yet not also common cross-linguistic properties found in expressives around the world. What works for a dependent-marking language with many phonemic vowels in Nakh-Daghestanian simply will not work for more polysynthetic languages with few vowels found in

Abkhaz-Adyghean, nor yet again for Kartvelian which is both polysynthetic and yet has a famously complicated system of dependent case-assignment.

This paper also looked in considerable depth at the behavior of one Caucasian language, Georgian, and found that the behavior of expressives is not uniform even within this single language. Different subclasses of expressives may manifest different kinds of exponence, either categorically or statistically, and other categories may crosscut these generalizations. Thus while verbs for manner of speaking, emission of light, emission of sound, and salient kinds of movement in Georgian all have a tendency to behave like ‘medial’ verbs which are atelic and agentive, verbs of emission of light are far more likely to have extreme consonant clusters in verb stems. On the other hand, all ingressive expressives, irrespective of their lexical semantics, belong to another morphosyntactic class altogether. Because the different classes of expressive behave in different ways in different contexts, Georgian thus shows that expressives are not one thing, but many different things, one thrown into sharp relief by the fascinating but typologically unusual system of Georgian morphosyntax more generally.

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